

Facebook Turns 20 and Changes Business Model

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Facebook, the dean of social networks, has just turned twenty. Irresistible, around the world, is the temptation to propose balances, judgments, and forecasts about its future. Over two billion people, a quarter of the world's population, access its pages every day, but in the United States, in the last two years, 13% of teenage users have abandoned it in favor of other social networks. It remains, in short, the most used social platform in the world, but it seems, by now, incapable of capturing the tastes of younger users. However, it is important not to forget that many of those teenagers fleeing from Facebook have landed on and use Instagram and WhatsApp daily, which did not exist when Facebook was born and which share the parent company Meta with it. Similarly, the data regarding Facebook's spread around the world are not definitive because, while it is true that in the U.S. and Europe, user growth is much slower than in the past, it is equally true that, in the Global South, the numbers of new users are soaring.

It is difficult to make predictions. Without forgetting that twenty years of a social network probably equate to over a century for a living person or a traditional company because in the world of bits, things move quickly, and the distance between stars and dust is often measured in weeks. Interpreting the desires of a quarter of humanity every day, twenty years after the first time, is a result that Facebook shares with very few other tech giants around the world: Google, Apple, Amazon, and Microsoft. Therefore, it is too early to speak of a swan song, to prepare to intone the *de profundis*, or to talk about the end of an era.

Certainly, it is undeniable that Facebook is no longer what it once was. But, on the other hand, the digital market is no longer the one that the white and blue giant of social networks first conquered at great heights. It is, first and foremost, a more crowded market. And if one considers that the digital market is one in which the protagonists essentially compete for the time and attention of users, it is evident that with every new entry, there exists, at least potentially, the risk that those who were already there must give up some of their users' time. However, this does not seem to have happened at Facebook, if it is true, as Mark Zuckerberg announced with satisfaction in October, that he has even seen the average attention time of his users increase by 7% compared to the previous year.

But aside from competitors, there is no doubt that what is still called Facebook today has little in common with the creature that emerged from Zuckerberg's dormitory. "It is free and will always be," was the payoff that had adorned the logo of the social network for over two decades. Today it is no longer there, replaced by a decidedly less noble and radical "It is fast and simple." The basis of the change was initially a decision by the Italian antitrust authority, which reminded the social network that it could not present itself to the world as free, considering that its users paid with personal data for the right to use it. Thus, it was a real retreat by the men of Menlo Park who, pressed by European personal data protection authorities that contested their thesis that it was the users who requested personalized advertising, decided to "take off the mask" and start asking users to choose whether to consent to being profiled for promotional purposes or to pay a monthly subscription. In short, Facebook perhaps was never truly free even when it claimed to be, but certainly, it is not today. A significant difference.

However, if one seeks reasons to believe that, likely, beyond appearances, Facebook is far from its terminus, the first and most important of all is probably represented by the level of accuracy with which the most popular and longest-lasting social network of all time knows us. A wealth of knowledge about billions of people that very few in the digital arena can claim to share, and a wealth that, especially in a season where algorithms extraordinarily hungry for personal data will increasingly determine success and failure in the markets, can and will guarantee the white and blue social network a long life, even as it changes its skin dozens of times. But the giant has a heel of Achilles. Its current business model – pay or ok, pay or consent to the processing of personal data – is sub iudice, and if the European personal data protection authorities were to decide that it is not acceptable because it commodifies a fundamental right like privacy beyond sustainable limits, it would not be easy for Zuckerberg and his managers to find an alternative solution to continue extracting wealth and power at least from the

European deposits of personal data. At that point, the next twenty years would truly not be a given.